

You Have Made Him Little Less Than God

A Discussion of the Virtue of Humility

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A. Introduction

The essay before you deals with various reflections on the virtue of humility (anavah). These reflections are drawn mainly from my own personal outlook, and only to a relatively small degree from the study of the words of the early and later halakhic authorities. This "disconnect" from traditional Jewish ethical literature is not merely literary but also substantive — one can sense that the tone and direction toward which I strive in this essay sound a note different from what is customary in this literature. This fact, evident in the relative scarcity of citations and exegetical discussions in the essay, would seemingly require some clarification regarding the legitimacy and the ability to depart from the traditional direction concerning the religious character of man, why this is possible and even important in our particular era, and so forth.

I choose to skip such a prefatory justification. This is not because I do not share the various arguments that have already established such a justification;^[1] on the contrary, my entire world is built and grounded upon these matters, which have already been written by Rav Kook and elaborated by his students and scholars. However, in the context of the study of character traits and ethics, it seems to me that this justification is unnecessary. The purpose of the study of character traits, as I see it, is to bring about the maximal inner refinement of a person, to draw him near to his Maker, and to advance him along the rungs of moral and spiritual perfection. Since this is its sole purpose, the terms we should use are not concepts of true and false, but concepts of gain and loss, of "benefit" in its highest, supreme sense. The measurement of the spiritual benefit of this or that approach or outlook can be performed only by means of intuition, inner listening, and sincere, penetrating reflection into the depths of the soul. This is not a matter of a "correct" definition or of setting a dogma of how this trait should look and how it should be acquired; each person, for himself, will adopt the moral ideas in which he finds goodness and uprightness, through which he feels elevation, refinement, betterment and closeness to God.

Accordingly, my words in this essay do not come to exclude other approaches regarding the virtue of humility, for two reasons. The first reason is that no idea, definition or formulation can encompass the full range of the human soul. The complexity of man creates a need for various explanations, various "pieces of advice," and from each of these pieces of advice there is something to take. The humility I will sketch in what follows is not a complete, closed picture; every different picture of humility, and certainly those expressed in the traditional sources of Jewish ethical literature, has a unique and vital point of light, which

ought to be clarified, taken, and put to a person's use. The second reason is that even where there is a "dispute," there is no need at all to resolve it by the methods of dispute. People differ from one another in their personality, in their psychic character, in their inner spiritual makeup; it is hard to imagine a single way suited to everyone, given their unique qualities, style and traits. Each reader will examine what is said, look into his own soul and search his heart as to which approaches help him more to rise and advance spiritually, and even if this is a thought not drawn from our ancient sources, its value as truth is measured only in relation to himself and his own benefit.

B. The Purpose of Lowliness

We have already noted in the previous chapters that humility is among the excellent traits, and is intermediate between arrogance and lowliness of spirit... and we have already explained, in the fourth chapter, that a person should properly lean toward one of the two extremes for the sake of a safeguard, so as to become fixed in the mean of actions — except for this one trait alone, among all the traits, I mean: arrogance. For, owing to the great harm of this trait among the pious, and their knowledge of its damage, they distanced themselves from it to the utmost extreme, and leaned entirely toward lowliness of spirit, so that they would leave no trace of arrogance in the soul whatsoever.

And I have seen, in one of the books of ethical literature, that a certain pious man was asked: what was the happiest day that ever passed over you in your life? He said: the day I was traveling on a ship, and my place on it was the lowliest of places, and I was dressed in tattered rags, and on the ship were merchants and men of wealth, and I was lying in my place, and one of the men of the ship rose to relieve himself, and my lowliness in his eyes, and the meanness of the state I was in, were such that he exposed himself and relieved himself upon me. And I marveled at the boldness fortified in his soul, and, by the life of the LORD, my soul was not grieved at all by his deed, nor was any anger aroused in it; and I rejoiced with a great joy that I had reached a level at which this deficient disgrace did not grieve me, and I did not take it to heart. And there is no doubt that this is the purpose of lowliness of spirit — that one should distance himself from arrogance.

Rambam, Commentary on the Mishnah, Avot 4:4

In these words the Rambam establishes the proper attitude toward the trait of lowliness. He teaches that although he argued — in the fourth of the Eight Chapters that introduce his commentary on tractate Avot — that, generally, the proper trait is always found between the extreme traits, with a slight tendency toward the lesser-negative of the two, regarding humility and lowliness the aspiration ought to be different. Because of the total revulsion toward, and rejection of, the trait of arrogance, nothing is fitting for a person except the opposite extreme, at the peak of possible extremity. The story the Rambam brings from "one of the books of ethical literature" is meant to demonstrate to us just how far that extreme of extreme lowliness can reach, and the deed of that pious man appears to be held up as exemplary.

One might say that the common feeling upon encountering these words is a lack of identification, and the shock the story produces in us illustrates this. It seems that something basic in our value-based and moral judgment of the story cries out when it encounters such a disgrace committed by one person against another, whoever he may be; and there is almost no response that would not be justified, from our point of view, in order to restore the most basic self-respect that has been stolen from him. Against this natural feeling, which seems to us healthy and vital to a great degree, the pious man mentioned did not become angry, nor was wrath or even sorrow aroused in him. Instead of worrying about his honor, the pious man is filled with ecstatic joy over the spiritual level he has attained through this humiliating situation.

Before we confront and enter into the full depth of the Rambam's conception, we must clarify and precisely determine the nature of the lowliness he speaks so highly of. It must be clearly distinguished that in the lowliness presented here there is no dimension whatsoever of a lack of self-worth. The pious man does not feel, and does not even believe in his heart, that the humiliation befits his worth, or that that brazen person deserves honor equal to or greater than his own. One can see that his attitude toward that brazen person even contains a certain haughtiness, to the point that he calls him "the deficient one," while at the same time he acknowledges the level he has attained and rejoices in the high rank he has achieved.

These words recall the (seeming) paradox pointed out by R. Baruch of Kosov:

Furthermore, this is difficult for me: what is the matter of humility, and what is its essence? For consider: if he is a person of stature, who knows and recognizes his own stature and superiority over the rest of humankind, and nevertheless lowers himself and hears his own disgrace and reviling and remains silent — this is nothing but a hypocrite. For since, in his own eyes, in his own thought, he thinks that he has a superior stature over the rest of humankind, and his stature is significant in his own eyes, it turns out that inwardly, in his thought, he has an inner arrogance... And if he does not recognize his own superiority over the rest of humankind, and thus is genuinely humble — then he is a fool, for not recognizing his own superiority. Moreover, if he does not recognize his own superiority, what merit is there in his being humble...

Amud Ha-Avodah, Homily on Humility

R. Baruch of Kosov's difficulty stems from an implicit assumption regarding the essence of the trait of humility. In his view, humility includes within it a certain lowliness of self-worth; the humble person is one who does not think himself of worth, who is not important and does not consider himself of stature in his own eyes. From this the paradox is born — for if he is truly humble, this is indeed a virtue, and can it possibly be said that in order to preserve this virtuous trait he must close his eyes and practice self-deception? Does humility include self-denial and inner falsification, which R. Baruch calls being a "fool"? Is self-transparency and an honest recognition of my own spiritual level truly an obstacle to virtuous traits and to spiritual perfection?

From here it seems one may say that, in the view of the Rambam, or in the view of the pious man whose words were cited above, the focus of the lowliness sought is not a diminished self-assessment; alongside the knowledge that he is a person of stature and worth, the pious man is thrilled that he has succeeded in not reacting, not relating to, not being moved by the disgrace — and this is his virtue.

In effect, the story tells us that although the pious man knows well that the man's deed is a vile act without equal, and that it is not fitting to behave this way toward anyone, he himself nevertheless remains indifferent to it; his personal humiliation occurs on a plane to which the pious man grants no reality at all, as though it were a matter that does not touch him. The lowliness, then, is not blindness, and it is fully aware of the moral perversion present in one person's disgracing of another, but, on the other hand, it neutralizes all the meaning and all the natural, egoistic emotional content that is aroused in a person in the face of his own humiliation. But if so, it is not clear how this neutralization occurs. What does the pious man say to himself, what does he say in his heart that cancels the feeling of self and the feeling of anger, while he recognizes that the deed done against him is indeed unjust? If the deed is indeed rejected in his eyes, how does he justify it to himself, how does he not rise up against it?

The answer to this question will become clear once we understand the Rambam's approach more deeply.

C. The Contradiction in the Rambam's Words

The following stage in discussing the Rambam's words is drawn entirely from the words of Rav Shagar.[2] In this essay I do indeed add my own touch — both in the part of the essay that does not deal with the Rambam's teaching, and in a broader elaboration of the basic distinction Rav Shagar proposes in his words (below); but a central part of the formation of the idea I owe to this source.

In the first chapter of Hilkhhot De'ot, the Rambam presents the straight path of a person as one whose every psychic tendency — his "de'ot" (dispositions) — is fully balanced, in the mean.

The straight path is the intermediate measure in each and every disposition that a person has, that is, the disposition equally distant from the two extremes, not close to either one nor the other; therefore the earlier sages commanded that a person should always assess his dispositions, and estimate them, and direct them along the middle path... How so? He should not be quick-tempered, easily angered, nor like the dead, who feels nothing, but in between... And so with all his other dispositions; and this path is the path of the wise, and every person whose dispositions are intermediate, balanced dispositions is called wise.

Mishneh Torah, Hilkhhot De'ot 1:4

Immediately after this description, he continues and describes the pious person (chasid), the one who acts beyond the letter of the law:

And one who is exceedingly exacting with himself, and departs slightly from the intermediate disposition to one side or the other, is called pious (chasid). How so? One who departs from haughtiness of heart to the very extreme, and is exceedingly lowly of spirit, is called pious, and this is the trait of piety; but if he departs only to the mean, and is humble, he is called wise, and this is the trait of wisdom; and so with all the other dispositions... And this is beyond the letter of the law. And we are commanded to walk in these middle ways, which are the good and straight ways, as it is said, "and you shall walk in His ways."

Ibid., 1:5

From the sum of the Rambam's words in chapter 1, it appears that the Rambam sketches the minimal demand, that of the wise person, as the precise intermediate measure, and describes this intermediate measure as "the good and straight ways" in which we are commanded to walk, while, in parallel, he sketches a yet higher ideal of the pious person, who tilts from the middle toward the more excellent trait.[3]

All this stands in contradiction to what the Rambam writes in the next chapter:

And there are dispositions regarding which a person is forbidden to conduct himself in the intermediate way; rather, he must move away from one extreme to the other extreme, and this is haughtiness of heart — for the good way is not that a person merely be humble, but that he be lowly of spirit, and that his spirit be very low; therefore it is said of Moses our teacher that he was "very humble," and it is not said merely "humble"; therefore the Sages commanded, "be exceedingly, exceedingly lowly of spirit"... And so too anger is an exceedingly bad trait, and it is fitting for a person to move away from it to the other extreme, and to teach himself not to become angry even over a matter that would justify anger... Therefore they commanded that one distance himself from anger to the point of training himself not to feel it even in the face of things that provoke anger, and this is the good way.

Ibid., 2:3

The Rambam's words appear to exclude from the general principle of the study of character traits — the one he described in the previous chapter — the traits of arrogance and anger. From the traits of arrogance and anger a person is obligated to distance himself to the extreme, and not only is the intermediate measure in them not "a good way," it is forbidden. But these words stand in absolute contradiction to his explicit statements in chapter 1, both regarding the trait of humility and lowliness and regarding the trait of anger! Extremity is presented here not merely as an aspiration toward a higher religiosity, but as the basic religious demand, whereas in chapter 1 intermediate humility and intermediate anger are presented as the good ways in which the wise man walks.

A contradiction this sharp is difficult to genuinely resolve within the Rambam's own words. However, Rav Shagar proposes a certain explanation which, even if it does not resolve the actual state of mind of the Rambam himself as he wrote, is nonetheless beautiful and worthy in itself, in the content of the matter.

The figures discussed in the first chapter are the wise man as against the pious man. In order to shed light on the difference between the wise man and the pious man, let us examine his words in Hilkhot Melakhim, which mention this very same difference again, in a different context:

Anyone who accepts the seven commandments [of the sons of Noah] and is careful to perform them is among the pious of the nations of the world, and has a portion in the World to Come — provided he accepts them and performs them because the Holy One commanded them in the Torah, and made known through Moses our teacher that the sons of Noah had already been commanded regarding them previously. But if he performs them out of a conclusion of the intellect, he is not [counted as] a resident alien, and is not among the pious of the nations of the world, but among their wise men.

Mishneh Torah, Hilkhot Melakhim 8:11

The wise man is the person who acts out of his human comprehension, out of his independent intellect. He does what is upright and beautiful, but in a world which, from his standpoint, is devoid of God; his ethical path, the way he organizes the forces of his soul, he draws from his moral intuition, as a person living within human society, in which it would be most pleasant and good to live if everyone walked in upright and good ways. The pious man, by contrast, acts out of the divine command, out of a religious motive. His gaze is not fixed upon society, upon the world, but upon heaven. The second chapter of Hilkhot De'ot should be seen as guidance suited to the pious man's world. In his eyes, intermediate humility is not a legitimate option at all; this is because the pious man's mode of existential consciousness is religious — that is, the primary orientation in his world is standing before God.

What is the connection between religious consciousness and extreme lowliness? I will illustrate this essential connection through the Rambam's description of the rejoicing at the Water-Drawing Ceremony (Simchat Beit Ha-Sho'evah):

The joy that a person feels in performing a commandment and in the love of God who commanded them is a great form of service (avodah); and anyone who withholds himself from this joy deserves to be punished, as it is said, "because you did not serve the LORD your God with joy and gladness of heart." And anyone who puffs himself up and grants himself honor and glorifies himself in his own eyes in these settings is a sinner and a fool, and of this Solomon warned, saying, "Do not glorify yourself before the king." But anyone who lowers himself and treats his body lightly in these settings is the truly great and honored one, who serves out of love. Thus David, king of Israel, said, "and I will be yet more lightly esteemed than this, and will be lowly in my own eyes"; and

greatness and honor belong only to one who rejoices before the LORD, as it is said, "and King David leaped and danced before the LORD."

Mishneh Torah, Hilkhot Shofar, Sukkah, ve-Lulav 8:15

In the words of Rav Shagar, "behavior that is correct and fitting in general is meaningless at the time of standing before God. Insistence on honor at such a time is a way of folly. The sense of divine presence changes the scale, turns normal human conduct into something ridiculous."

Rav Shagar proposes that we see the wise man and the pious man not as two distinct and contradictory types, but as two planes of existence, which can dwell together within a single person. A person must be "a citizen of two worlds" — he can contain within himself both the "wise" type, the type that draws its ethical path from a patient, clear-minded observation of the world around it, and also the "pious" type, driven by religious enthusiasm, by a self-forgetting devotion to God. Actual conduct is dependent on the psychic context. A person behaves wisely in relation to society — he walks in humility, but on the other hand knows his own worth and is not lowly of spirit; but, by contrast, he behaves with piety, with deep, ecstatic religious ardor, when he comes before God, and there, there is no room for honor, nor for anger, but rather, on the contrary, for extreme self-lowering.

Let us return to the story the Rambam brings in his commentary on tractate Avot about the pious man on the ship. The story seems shocking to us because we examine it from the social plane of what occurs; and indeed, from a "wise" point of view, an injustice occurs here that deserves to be cried out against, and even to be angered by. But since the story deals with a pious man, and comes to illustrate the way of the pious, it must be understood precisely against the background of what we have written above — the pious man lives out of enthusiastic religious devotion, and stands himself before God at all times. This standing before a great and awesome God grants him a sense of infinite lowliness, and he is filled with great joy when given the opportunity to express this lowliness in reality. His behavior is not directed toward the surrounding society, but only toward heaven, and therefore there is no contradiction between his knowledge that the deed done to him is indeed unfitting and does not suit his relative-value standing in society, and his ability not to rise up against it at all, and even to reach, from it, an ecstatic experience.

This is also the solution to the paradox we presented at the opening of our discussion: true lowliness can, in truth, exist specifically because, alongside the pious man's consciousness, the wise man's consciousness also lives within him, in which it is understood that the humiliating deed does not befit his stature, and it is fitting to react to it. Only when there exists, on a certain existential plane, a recognition of the wrongness of the deed, is there any moral significance to the "pious" overcoming and disengagement from this plane, and its nullification by fleeing from the relative-social plane to the plane of the objective, null value of the self in relation to the infinite sublimity of God.

D. The Source of Honor

Up to this point I have briefly presented Rav Shagar's special explanation of the Rambam's teaching regarding humility.[5] These words are beautiful and complete in themselves, but on further reflection I found that I could not fully understand the reason for the distinction — why, on the religious plane, do I forget my relative worth, and why, on the social plane, do I forget my "objective" worth? The words seemed to me on target, and yet I saw the need to add an explanation to them, and I will do this through an analysis of the concept of natural self-honor.

The starting point is that every psychic force that truly exists within us has a foundational positive significance, and one must investigate and understand its original, natural, correct place. It seems to me that at the foundation of the discussion of lowliness and anger, of the reaction or non-reaction to disgrace, stands the concept of honor (kavod). A person is born naturally possessing honor; this is a real psychic force that constitutes part of one's personal content and of the array of one's spiritual "instincts" — "for You have made him but little lower than God, and have crowned him with glory and honor." [6] The root of this honor is the image of God (tzelem Elohim) within man. [7] This honor requires that one be related to in the fitting manner, and the trampling of a person's worth is a violation of his honor, because it constitutes a violation of the metaphysical fact that man is a special and lofty creation of the Creator, who elevated him above all His creatures to the rank of His own image. Hence human dignity (kevod ha-beriyot) is a halakhic value, and there is likewise a prohibition against violating a person's honor — even one's own honor — and one who does so commits a very grave act.

The explanation of the concept of honor by way of the image of God within man is not merely a piece of metaphysical dialectic, but a real, true experience. A person experiences his honor and the sense of worth he owes himself not from some private, narrow point, but from the very pillar of the world; he participates in the splendor and majesty of the King of kings of kings. Beyond this, this explanation has implications on the existential-practical plane. A person who is aware that the source of the aspiration to honor lies in his having been created in the divine image aspires to a different kind of honor — he strives only for the most basic honor due to him by the very fact of his creation, regardless of his status, achievements, choices and successes. The honor he permits himself to lay claim to is an egalitarian honor, fitting for every person simply by virtue of being human. And therefore, on the one hand, anger and insult receive essential validation — the sense of injustice at an act of humiliation comes not from an egoistic place, but from a place of the most upright sense of justice. In truth this is not fitting, and my anger at it is the most legitimate and natural expression of the abnormality of a situation in which one person disgraces another, and not some selfish narrowness that must be fought. On the other hand, the fundamental egalitarian character of honor also defines and narrows its scope of application — I am hurt only because of the violation of equality, because of the coarse behavioral deviation that removes and lowers me from the basic, fitting relation due to every human being. But I do not arrive at the point of taking offense with all of my baggage, with all my personality, virtues, traits, ego and self-regard; on the contrary, when I am stripped of all these, and only

from this foundational point is my pain just and my anger legitimate. This is the very same anger that ought to stir within me when I see an identical violation done to someone else.

In this explanation also lies the account of the sharp difference between the plane of social existence and the plane of religious existence with regard to honor and lowliness. Since the source of honor is the image of God within man, it is specifically in the presence of other human beings that a person's basic experience should be equality; an equality that, on the one hand, causes me to behave with humility, with simplicity and without haughtiness, and, on the other hand, both sharpens and also clarifies and justifies my anger at being humiliated beyond what is fitting. This is precisely the intermediate measure the Rambam spoke of in describing humility. But for that very same reason, the entire sense of self-honor is nullified when it stands before the Creator; for what is the bearer of the image compared to its infinite source, what is the worth of a spark compared to the greatness of the tremendous flame, what is the form compared to its Former? Precisely the consciousness of honor that rests on the foundation of the image of God prostrates and bows down to the earth before God Himself, in His glory. Out of this experience of self-nullification and absorption within the infinite, great and awesome divine source, one can understand the pious man's longing for lowliness, and David's experience when he said, "and I will play before the LORD, and I will be yet more lightly esteemed than this, and will be lowly in my own eyes." [8]

E. The Third Plane — Self-Relation

Up to this point, humility has been discussed from the perspective of relation — that is, humility was portrayed as a mode of self-relation in the context of a relation, a connection to another: a religious connection of standing before God, on the one hand, and a social connection of being within society, or before the human other, on the other hand. But it seems to me that these words do not exhaust the full range of proper self-relation to be adopted by a person; they do not encompass the sum of his existential planes. For this reason, I wish to propose a further perspective on humility, found on a third plane, that of standing before oneself. In a person's standing before himself, we neutralize humility's proximity to the concepts of anger, honor and humiliation. This is a question that stands on its own, without a particular test case and without any specific behavior. In this it is, perhaps, the most fundamental question in clarifying the essence of humility.

It seems that the psychic source of the problem of arrogance is shared with the problem of one person's envy of another. In both these phenomena, the weighing of the externalized gaze upon myself finds expression — in arrogance I seek to be filled and strengthened by this externalized gaze, while in envy I suffer from its diminishing consequences. The arrogant person seeks his affirmation and his sense of self-fullness from the external gaze. He seeks to be recognized as possessing greater worth than others, since he believes that only this will slake his thirst for honor, which expresses an existential experience of wholeness, of joy and of the self's satisfaction in itself. [9] Instead of living from a place that is truly his own, one that draws its vitality and meaning from within itself and from the

inner content of his life, the arrogant person squints at the mirror, and needs support from the objective gaze upon himself — whether this is the gaze of society and of others upon him, or his own gaze measured by the external-social standards by which a person is measured.

This is the very same problem underlying the complex of envy. Since a person seeks to measure and assess himself and his worth, he finds himself examining himself with an outside gaze. This gaze, like all observation — both on the physical plane and on the plane of various spiritual meanings — is subject to a foundational principle called proportion. When we see a new object in some space, our brain absorbs and translates the size of the object by means of its relative comparison to the objects around it. The same can be seen in the immaterial domain of judgment — we judge and assess deeds, people, grades, titles, and, in effect, everything that exists around us, by comparing them to their counterparts of the same kind, and thus determine our relation to them. When a person adopts the external outlook even toward himself, he is forced to rely on the relative perspective, and thus finds himself comparing his traits and his quality to the human other in his environment. Out of this relative perspective, insofar as he finds that some of the other's traits are indeed greater and better than his own, he falls into envy.

Sometimes a person falls in his own estimation, upon hearing of the greatness of another category that is not his own measure, and becomes as nothing in his own eyes, and sorrow begins to dim the radiance of his soul, because his entire spiritual standing then becomes dim before that measure of greatness, which is not for his worth. He must then strengthen himself, so as not to envy another's portion... and in any case he should be content and rejoice greatly in his own portion, and continue to hold fast to his stronghold, and then his light will break forth like the dawn, and his healing will spring forth quickly.

Orot Ha-Kodesh (Arpilei Tohar), p. 80

Rav Kook proposes, as a remedy for the complex of envy, inner self-strengthening, which, in light of what I have written above, can be interpreted as the abandonment of the external outlook upon myself, and its replacement with inner contemplation, with inner listening and self-trust. When I cease to look at myself from without, I stop being bound to the relative-proportional gaze, and I can draw self-worth directly and immediately from the experience of inner strength, from the experiences of my own wholeness and self-perfection.

In what follows I wish to walk a further path, different from the one Rav Kook proposes. This different path does not contradict the Rav's principled words, and does not seek to replace them in their centrality. These words are written out of a sense that, although his authentic and powerful approach does indeed bring healing and great vitality to the soul, and although it sounds to me correct and advancing, it alone is not sufficient. The reason for this is that although one should indeed direct efforts to divert one's inner orientation away from the external-comparative gaze upon oneself, toward inner listening and self-

empowerment and self-trust, these efforts will never "win" in the final sense of the word. There is no way to entirely, totally overcome the reflective-relative gaze upon oneself, since this is a gaze embedded in the concrete existence of the human being, in his being a social creature possessing the capacity for perception, analysis and conceptualization.

F. Strategies of Contemplation

Throughout the generations, many thinkers have proposed various contemplative practices meant to lead to the virtue of humility. In this, as I understand it, they went in a different direction than the one Rav Kook proposed above,[10] and sought not to uproot the "objective" self-gaze, but to direct it toward good and desirable places. What was the content of the contemplative practices they proposed?

It seems to me that one can classify most approaches to the virtue of humility into three central directions of contemplation, three strategies for coping with arrogance, which we will call — "self-flagellation," "self-comparison," and "self-nullification."

The first strategy calls upon a person to focus his gaze on his negative and low sides. This is an approach that confronts self-inflation in the most simplistic and direct way — against thoughts of greatness, set thoughts of smallness; against self-regard, set an absence of self-regard; against a feeling of fullness and satisfaction, set thoughts of incompleteness and discontent. The way to cope with arrogance is by fixing one's gaze on man's flaws — both man in general and the specific individual — and on his great distance from the splendor he attributes to himself in his arrogance.

Heavy use of this strategy raises several existential problems. One problem is a feeling of self-deception — a person who trains himself to contemplate his own inferiorities may feel that he is not acting with fairness and "intellectual honesty" toward himself, since he does not judge himself by just or true criteria, but always seeks only the bad within himself. For all the importance that sometimes lies in deflating false, inflated arrogance and confronting it head-on, it is hard to overcome the sense that the self-diminishing contemplation is itself no less false, since its entire orientation is to raise to consciousness the negative, small and shameful sides that exist within a person, and not to set before him his true portrait in any genuine sense. Another problem is the price of low stature. Humility shaped by "self-flagellating" contemplation is indeed very far from seeking greatness and honor, but it contains no positive, constructive, motivating component; this is a humility that not only fails to push a person forward, but in many senses blocks his progress, distances him from ambition, from joy, from taking responsibility, and from all the important virtues that flow from a person's basic self-regard.[11]

The second strategy is a refinement of the first, and it too aims to lower a person in his own eyes. Instead of enumerating a person's inferiorities, instead of shifting the gaze to search out his sins and flaws, the person is asked to find some high point of reference against which to compare himself, and thereby understand the lowliness of his own stature. If you think you are wise — examine your wisdom in relation to the sages of this generation and of

previous generations; if you think you are righteous, compare yourself to the great figures of the nation; and so on in this way. One can perform this diminishing comparison in several variations — some have proposed comparing yourself, each time, to those of your acquaintances whom you see as superior to you in that particular domain; some have proposed comparing yourself to angels, and others have proposed setting your own virtues in comparison to the Holy One, thereby attaining a sense of total relative nothingness; and there is also a more sophisticated proposal, namely, to compare yourself — in the domain of righteousness and spiritual-religious virtue — to the obligation incumbent upon you, to the infinite religious standard to which you are bound by force of gratitude to God and by force of the command "to serve Him with all your heart and with all your soul." [12]

Even in this approach, although it does not necessarily involve a denial of a person's positive sides, there is some sense of dishonesty in the very fact that we decide to compare ourselves specifically to a point of reference that, a priori, will certainly be higher than us. In some cases the comparison itself is unreasonable, and this removes part of its sting — the fact that, when I stand in relative view "beside" the angels, or, to distinguish, beside the Holy One, I appear small and null, says, in point of truth, nothing about me at all; this is an "unfair," baseless comparison. Here too, a person will find himself torn between the blessed, humility-producing result of the contemplation and the feelings of injustice and dishonesty that arise from that same contemplation.

G. Nullification

The third strategy proceeds in a different direction, and we will illustrate it from the words of the Ramchal:

Indeed, one who possesses straight intellect, even if he has merited to be a truly great and exceptional sage, when he looks and reflects, will see that there is no room for pride and self-exaltation. For behold, one who possesses an intellect that knows more than others does nothing but what is proper to his nature to do, like a bird that soars aloft, because that is its nature. And the ox pulls with its strength, because that is its portion. For one who is wise is so because his nature brings him to this. And had the one who is not now as wise as he possessed a natural intellect like his, he too would become wise like him. If so, there is no room here for self-exaltation and pride...

...For behold, every attainment he achieves is nothing but the grace of God upon him, who wishes to favor him, even though, by nature and materiality, he is exceedingly lowly and contemptible. Therefore he has nothing to do but give thanks to the One who favored him, and to humble himself always the more... Behold, then, that a person should not even take credit to himself for his own good qualities, and how much more so should he not exalt and elevate himself because of them.

Mesillat Yesharim, chapter 22

What is special about this approach is that it does not direct a person's gaze toward his flaws, nor does it seek to create a self-presentation of lowliness; its way of coping with

feelings of importance and greatness is not through direct battle, but through removing the entire sting from these very thoughts. Indeed, it may be that you possess excellent traits, it may be that you deserve, by virtue of your standing and your qualities, honor and glory — but this is not to your credit, it does not truly belong to you; your good traits have nothing whatsoever to do with your own selfhood, with the point of "I" within you, since all these are possessions given to you by the grace of God. This contemplation takes thoughts of self-greatness and self-inflation and empties them of all content, since even if they are correct as a matter of fact, objectively speaking, they no longer carry any ego-nourishing significance.

The nullifying contemplation has many advantages. Unlike the other options, it does not demand self-deception, and it does not call upon a person to look at himself with a hostile or distorted eye. The outlook remains as it is, and room is created for me to be honest with my own basic self-assessment. Even the "nullifying" contemplation itself, which attributes all the good within me to the divine source, contains a great truth that shines through it. The humility-producing experience created by this nullification is not one of bowed stature, but of an illuminating religious experience. This is, in effect, a transformation of arrogance into joy — joy in myself, in my own goodness — and the tuning of that joy toward gratitude and praise, toward a psychic state of religious enthusiasm, devotion (*deveikut*) and shelter in the shadow of the Creator's wings.

That said, the path of nullification too has a problem of a certain lack of inner identification, and rightly so. The nullifying contemplation leaves the self-conception, seemingly, exactly as it is, and uproots from within it only a single point — the feeling of entitlement to all those traits in which it rejoices and takes pride. But in uprooting the feeling of entitlement, the nullifying outlook, in effect, directly disregards the very pillar of the picture of man — free choice. The entire claim of nullification is that the good things within you do not truly belong to you, since you did not create them, you did not labor for them, and therefore you have no ownership of them. But the honest, authentic feeling often calls out otherwise — indeed, they are mine! I strove, I overcame, I rose! I am the one who improved myself, who advanced my own traits and talents; I, by my own courageous will and my own good choice, cultivated and developed these precious qualities in which I take pride. This feeling of fullness from oneself is not necessarily unfounded; it is not false, nor is it always exaggerated. At bottom, a person's free choice indeed carries great weight in shaping his character, and to deny this would run counter to the basic worldview of Judaism.

Hence a rigorous work of analysis is required. Within a person there are both innate character traits and acquired character traits. The first stage of the work of humility is to discern, through fine contemplation, what within me arrived from within myself, from my own good, free choice, and what I owe to what lies outside me — whether these are the conditions of life I was given, the upbringing and environment I was granted, or the talents with which I was blessed from birth. Regarding everything I received from without, I indeed have no ability to be proud, to be full of myself — only to give thanks and rejoice, together with maintaining a balanced and precise self-assessment, and caution against exaggeration and against improper self-elevation.

H. Myself to Myself, What Am I

What remains for us, then, is to seek how to deal with what remains truly "ours"; how to relate to and assess the sides of myself in which I feel genuine pride, which are truly mine by right, the sides of me that are the fruit of my own choice and labor.

I wish to propose here a further path, one close to, though distinct from, the last variation we brought under the category of "self-comparison." The central self-contemplation, in my view, that ought to be used, is a contemplation that compares myself — to myself. That is: the point of reference that helps a person understand his smallness, his lowliness, his deficiency, is not found in some object existing outside him, but is he himself, in his own potential.

The work of humility is to set the actual "I" against the potential "I." The foundation of this work is trust in the infinite goodness that every person — inasmuch as he is created in the image of God, inasmuch as he is animated by a divine soul that is truly a portion of God from above — contains within himself, in his essence, in his capacity. When I understand that I myself — in potential — could go further, could rise higher, could be better, then my present, actual character, and the achievements I have reached thus far, take on their relative, null value, and I understand that I have nothing to be proud of. Not only could I have reached an incomparably loftier place, but it was fitting for me, it was necessary for me, it was suited to me — this is the truest place for me — and, through my own fault, I have missed it, and I now stand nowhere but where I stand. There is no real limit to a person's spiritual capacity; his soul reaches beyond all imagination, and every concrete achievement is limited and constrained relative to that core divine potential that forms the foundation of human being.

The trust, the inner recognition, and the ability to picture the magnitude of the good hidden within a person's soul, come not only from foundational beliefs regarding man's creation and his being composed of the divine spirit that breathes life into the body; they are also the result of inner contemplation. The way to grasp the potential good within me is by focusing on the actual good I already find within myself today, in practice:

And so a person must also find, even within himself... and even when he begins to look at himself and sees that there is no good in him at all, and that he is full of sins... he must not fall from this; he need only search and find within himself some small measure of good, for how is it possible that he never, in all his days, performed some commandment or good deed? And even when he begins to examine that good thing, he sees that it too is full of wounds and has no soundness — that is, he sees that even the commandment and the sacred deed he merited to perform is also full of ulterior motives and extraneous thoughts and many flaws — nevertheless, how is it possible that within that commandment or sacred deed there was not some small measure of good? For in any case, however it may be, there was in any case some good point in the commandment or good deed he performed. For a person must search and seek to find within himself some small measure of good, in order to give himself life and come to joy, as above...

The distillation of that concentrated "small measure of good," refined from all ulterior motive, which I labor to clarify and find within myself, brings me face to face with the tremendous quality of the good that exists within me, in potential, from every side. Because of this, it revives me, and grants me both trust in my own good essence and the conscious capacity to imagine and picture that potential good in its full manifestation, the "higher self" I am capable — by my own free choice — of actually attaining.

What do we gain from this contemplation of humility, in comparison to other paths to humility?

It seems one can point to several significant advantages. The humility produced by this outlook, which compares the actual self to the potential self, does not stand opposed to the part of a person that rejoices in his partial perfection, in his good qualities and his spiritual-moral achievements, and does not require a person to twist his gaze upon himself and deny these sides, or to deceive himself into thinking these achievements have no value. On the contrary — it is precisely the focus of the gaze on the good within me that is, as noted, the most effective and powerful cognitive tool for picturing the supreme perfection I could reach if I invested and strove more, and it is this very picture that brings me to the deepest and most sincere sense of humility. This contemplation of humility, although it strengthens the recognition of my own deficiency and of my exclusive responsibility for my condition — which is far from what it ought to be — brings me not to gloom and self-abasement but, on the contrary, to joy and enthusiasm, since I discover that in my inner essence I am good and upright, that my roots are in the infinite good, and that it dwells within me, hidden, waiting to be actualized. This is a humility steeped in sweetness, in optimism.

Beyond this, this humility leads to motivation and vigor, to the strengthening of my inner will to be actually better, to fulfill my calling, to actualize my supreme potential. That very same contemplation of the gap between the present "I" and the ideal "I" is precisely what points to the revolutionary, stirring recognition that "the matter depends on nothing but me." I understand that what separates reality from the ideal is nothing other than my own absolute freedom; from tomorrow, and even from the very next second, I can already be different, since my higher self already exists, it is real, it waits within me; only my poor choice holds it back, only my deviation from myself brings me down, and it is in my power — even from this very moment onward — to return to my true, perfect self.[13]

This work and concentration on the contemplation that compares myself to myself is a work performed on two different traits at once. Alongside a person's grappling with his own thoughts of greatness and arrogance about himself, this contemplation also constitutes a redirection of the basic force that leads a person to envy, which I elaborated on above. Since, as stated, a person is compelled to look at himself with an "objective," that is, relative-proportional, gaze, the natural and easy tendency is to compare himself to the other, to the human environment that surrounds him. But this comparison is inherently flawed, both because it is false — since no one has the ability to descend into the judgment of another's

worth and essence — and because it is unnecessary and harmful — since it will either lead to contempt for the other, or to a fall in self-worth and to narrow envy. When a person works on himself and redirects his comparative gaze inward, toward the plane spread between the concrete self and the potential self, he both rises above the dross of envy, which adds nothing constructive within him, and also crowns himself with the humility that contains all the qualities we have described above — a sincere, optimistic, exhilarating and motivating humility.

I. Summary

This essay has dealt with various insights regarding the virtue of humility. I began by presenting Rav Shagar's explanation of the contradiction found in the Rambam's words, from which it follows that one must distinguish between the plane of general-social existence, in which a person stands before society, and the plane of religious existence, of standing before God. On the social plane, a person is asked to be "wise," that is, to maintain an intermediate measure of humility, one that knows a person's worth and does not grant legitimacy to excessive self-abasement; whereas on the religious, "pious" plane of existence, a person does not feel his own worth, out of his self-nullification before the supreme divine infinite. I explained this distinction by means of the concept of honor, which flows from the image of God with which man is crowned. Honor is of man's essence, and is therefore among the basic rights of every human creature, as created in the image; hence it leads to a consciousness of equality in the human-social context, but to a nullification of value before the source, the Rock of the world.

This inquiry into the trait of humility belongs to the domain of the concepts of honor, anger and lowliness. The pivotal question in the discussion was what a person's attitude ought to be toward the other's relation to him; whether to feel oneself possessed of worth deserving of honor, and whether to stand upon one's honor. I then moved on to discuss the nature of a person's relation to himself, apart from the context of humiliation or honor from the other. The problem of arrogance, in this context, arises from a person's need to quantify and attribute his own worth, out of the external gaze upon himself that seeks the support of a sense of worth and self-fullness in "objective" categories and judgment.

I presented various proposals, offered in Jewish ethical literature, regarding the question of what a person should set before his eyes in order to escape arrogance. In conclusion, I proposed distinguishing between traits acquired by the power of choice and traits that are innate or granted to a person by grace, without his own elective effort. Regarding the latter, one should adopt the nullifying outlook, which attributes the sides of my personality in which I take pride to the divine grace that granted them to me. In this way a humility is formed whose essence is feelings of gratitude and joy in the goodness and beauty within me. Regarding the "elective" traits, I proposed a special contemplation, in which a person compares himself to himself — that is, I examine the spiritual, moral and religious standing at which I currently stand, as of now, and set it in relative comparison against the "potential self," who I am in my inner, soul-rooted, hidden essence; who I can be if only I remain

faithful to my own deep selfhood. This contemplation leads to a humility that contains further positive components beyond the mere suppression of repugnant arrogance, such as joy, a favorable eye, inner motivation toward self-strengthening, and the overcoming of the pull toward envy and toward a comparative gaze upon the other.

The basic yearning underlying the search undertaken in this essay is for a kind of character-work that does not ask a person to close his eyes or to uproot basic spiritual intuitions. The advantage — in my view — of the contemplative practices and concepts I have proposed in this essay lies in their fit with a person's natural feelings, as I, of course, sense them. My request has been to find a spiritual path that, on the one hand, weeds out a person's bad sides — narrow envy, the deceit of arrogance, and excessive self-glorification — but, on the other hand, does not uproot his healthy feelings, and does not seal him off from the deep, authentic and sincere voices that arise within him. And if only I have succeeded in this.

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Notes

1. See, for example, the book by my teacher, Rav Yuval Sherlo, *Ve'erastikh Li Le-Olam*, published by Yeshivat Hesder Petach Tikva, 5763.

2. Rav Shagar, "On Two Types of Humility," in *Nahalekh Be-Ragesh*, published by the Rav Shagar Writings Institute, pp. 104–109. Readers who are interested would do well to read the matter in its original place, and to skip to the next chapter ("The Source of Honor").

3. Already in halakhah 5 one can find a certain internal contradiction in the Rambam's words. The Rambam opens his description of the pious man as one who departs slightly from the intermediate measure, but immediately afterward, when illustrating the description of the pious man with regard to the trait of humility, he speaks of a radical departure "to the very extreme."

4. Although some printed editions have "and not among their wise men," this is the version found in the accurate editions, based on the manuscripts.

5. Anger is also included in this same discussion, since it is primarily a byproduct of the sense of self-worth shaped by the trait of humility or lowliness. Everything in the Rambam's words revolves around the matter of honor and the acceptance of disgrace.

6. Psalms 8:6.

7. A connection can be seen between the verses in Psalms chapter 8 and the story of the creation of man in the image of God. In Psalms it is written: "For You have made him but little lower than God, and have crowned him with glory and honor. You have made him to have dominion over the works of Your hands; You have put all things under his feet: sheep and oxen, all of them, and also the beasts of the field..."; and in the book of Genesis it is told: "And God said, let us make man in our image, after our likeness, and let them have dominion over the fish of the sea, and over the fowl of the air, and over the cattle, and over all the earth, and over every creeping thing that creeps upon the earth" (1:26). From this one may infer that the phrase "for You have made him but little lower than God" refers to the concept of the image of God, and from this it becomes possible to understand that the concept of a person's "honor" has a connection to the image of God within him.

8. 2 Samuel 6:21–22.

9. See the essay by Amichai Friedman, "On Honor and Loneliness," *Petichta 1*, published by Yeshivat Hesder Petach Tikva, where he defines honor as a person's capacity not to be existentially dependent on the other.

10. I am not claiming that this is Rav Kook's general position regarding the virtue of humility, and this is also evident from the subject of the words cited above from *Orot Ha-Kodesh* (*Arpilei Tohar*), which deal with the phenomenon of envy and self-"devaluation." I use his words in order to mark out a certain position, a certain approach, whose essence is the nullification of the outlook upon oneself "from without," in objective-relative criteria.

11. This critique of the "lowering" conception of humility was voiced by Rav Kook many times in his writings. See, for example: "One must sometimes remove entirely the low feelings, even though they serve, in holiness, for others, and don, in their place, more spiritual garments, fuller of radiance, more noble..." (*Arpilei Tohar*, p. 130). See the index to the writings of Ha-Re'iyah, p. 199, "positive arrogance."

12. See *Chovot Ha-Levavot*, *Sha'ar Ha-Keni'ah*, chapter 5, the fourth manner.

13. It is understood that, in the end, there is a more complex thought here, for it is clear that there is no possibility — and certainly not all at once — of climbing to the very summit of human perfection. The human will — for all that it is, from one point of view, entirely free — is also bound by human limitations of power and capacity. But in truth, the limitations are external to the point of will itself, and although, in practice, they hem it in and confine it, insofar as it is set within a broader and more complex psychic system, from the standpoint of its root and essence it is a free will. This deep inner experience, although it does not encompass the full breadth of the view of the matter, is the blessed outcome with which I am concerned here.